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Platforms and Their Power

Chapter 3 focuses on platforms, analyzing their political power and impact as intermediaries, distribution channels, infrastructure, technologies, and profit-making firms. The chapter is especially interested in the intersections between platforms, political institutions, journalism, and governmental bodies, as well as how platforms create new, technologically mediated social spaces. This chapter addresses platform products, design, affordances, and economics as they affect politics, and their self-governance through things such as content moderation policies (the book analyzes various state attempts at external, governmental regulation in [Chapter 9](#) on governance).

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- understand platforms and their roles in society
- analyze the dimensions of platform power
- understand technological power, including affordances and algorithms.

3.1 Introduction

Elon Musk, one of the richest people on Earth and an eccentric, libertarian entrepreneur, bought Twitter in autumn 2022. He promptly took the company private. In his chaotic first few weeks as the self-described “Chief Twit” of the company, people around the world were reminded of the volatile character of platforms. Platforms come, and platforms go. Platforms change their designs, affordances, and appearances as they evolve over time – or rapidly change. The rules governing them from the inside and outside change.

However, the sheer speed with Musk seemed to undo Twitter as the world knew it was breathtaking. In only a few days he laid off thousands of employees, seemingly capriciously, not only potentially breaking labor laws and regulations in various countries, but also losing some of the senior managers responsible for key issues such as data protection. There was no communication department anymore, and many remaining employees were called back from remote working to Twitter’s headquarters. Musk, it seemed, liked to break things and run an established company and platform previously publicly traded in start-up mode.

There were consequences of this change in ownership. Firing the company’s content moderators led to increased levels of hate and harassment (Center for Countering Digital Hate 2022). Re-activating far-right activist accounts brought a surge of racist and extremist content. At the same time, alternative platforms to Twitter gained much attention. Mastodon, a non-profit, open-source, de-centralized network of servers (called “instances”)

received a large share of the “Twitter migration” and had an explosion in new and active accounts. It remains to be seen whether moving to Mastodon was just short-term hype, or if a non-profit, ad-free platform run by its own administrators making their own rules will become a significant alternative to Twitter. What is important, however, is that Musk’s Twitter takeover was a powerful reminder that we should not trust platforms with all our data, rely on them as spaces for public discourse, or otherwise believe they will serve as digital services for eternity.

Many people also experienced first-hand how what researchers call “network effects” work. “Network effects” refers generally to how value lies in the number of people who use a service or a platform. Twitter users cannot simply transfer the followers they took years to gain to any other platform, let alone a new platform that is just getting started. Even with alternatives to the Musk-led platform, for many leaving Twitter means losing voice, reach, and community. And, given the role of collectives such as Black Twitter in holding police accountable and #MeToo in holding men accountable, it means losing potentially much more than that too.

3.2 So, What Are Platforms?

This seems like a simple question, but it is actually really complex! We refer to “platforms” casually every day when we search for information on Google, post on Facebook and TikTok, or purchase something on Amazon. But what makes each of these things the same thing? Search on Google is different from video on YouTube, after all. We take our lead from scholars José van Dijck, Thomas Poell, and Martijn de Waal (2018: 9) who define a “platform” as a “programmable architecture designed to organize interactions between users.” As these researchers go on to write:

A platform is fueled by *data*, automated and organized through *algorithms* and *interfaces*, formalized through *ownership* relations driven by *business models*, and governed through *user agreements*.

This is complicated – so let’s break it down a bit. This is a very helpful definition that gets us to what is so unique about our era – and that is a central part of this book. Namely, the fact that behind most contemporary political communication are commercial platforms that organize much of political (as well as social and entertainment!) life and interactions across a stunningly diverse array of *users*. In the realm of politics alone, *users* include campaigns, voters, elected representatives, political parties, social movements, think tanks, citizens, and advocacy organizations, among many others.

SPOTLIGHTED CASES

What does it mean that platforms “organize interactions among users” in the context of politics? Let’s think about a few concrete examples. Facebook does not produce journalism directly. Nor does it directly determine what news people consume.

Instead, Facebook provides a way for news media to reach audiences. Facebook also assesses journalistic credibility through Facebook News and elevates some outlets to serve as fact-checkers. Facebook also provides users with the ability to personalize the media they see through their own choices and engagement. The platform shapes public attention through the algorithmic design of its “newsfeed,” which displays content to users with the goal of increasing the time they spend on the platform (which is the way Facebook monetizes users). Similarly, Google does not maintain the vast majority of webpages the search engine links to. The platform indexes billions of pages of content, makes them searchable, and ranks them based on what it determines are the collective preferences of billions of users and structures of links. In the process, Google shapes the very ways billions of users navigate the web and content providers find audiences – with significant political implications (Noble 2018; Tripodi 2022).

While platforms vary, the definition provided above captures the common elements that underlie how many different platforms work to organize billions of daily interactions (Gillespie 2010). Platforms are centrally reliant upon data – the trillions of pieces of information they collect on who users are and what they like, how they behave, what they reveal, how they communicate and interact, and what they create. While they are very different, Facebook relies on data to prioritize the content to display to users, just as Google relies on user and link data to structure its search results. Especially important here is that *data* exist in systems, such as the algorithms that rely on data to deliver content, the interfaces that respond to data from and about users, the business models that help platforms generate revenue, and the data that enable platforms to determine threats to security and compliance with policies. Platforms rely on data about their users to design their features and ensure they are meeting their desires and needs. And, indeed, platforms produce those very desires through data-driven, targeted advertising – which most platforms rely on for monetization.

Indeed, data about users is valuable currency – so much so that some researchers have seen data as the cornerstone of contemporary capitalism and the basis for markets for advertising and goods and services (Van Dijck et al. 2018; Zuboff 2019). Data not only feeds the algorithms that shape what users see and do, in part by prioritizing particular types of content and interactions to monetize them – data is also a commodity that platforms sell to advertisers and data brokers. Data is the basis upon which platform companies directly sell their users to advertisers. They often do not provide data on users to advertisers directly; instead, they distill billions of points of data into categories of users that they auction off to advertisers (McGuigan 2019). These categories are often premised on probabilistic assessments of who is likely to purchase a particular good or service on the basis of prior behavior, attitudes, or preferences, as well as demographic characteristics.

Just as data are central to their operations, all platforms are programmable, in the sense that they are designed architectures. Design organizes those interactions between users, and

between users and information. Platforms can be *digital* architectures, *hardware* architectures, or both. In the former category, think about web-based applications such as Facebook and Amazon (which also rely on immense physical architectures, such as servers). The latter includes the Apple iPhone, Nintendo Switch, and the increasing array of hardware products that companies such as Meta and Google are investing in to deliver various services (and generate data). Look no further than virtual reality and the so-called “metaverse.”

So, for example, on a platform such as Facebook, programming determines the framework for what users disclose about themselves to other users and to the company itself, how users can interact with one another (such as becoming friends), how they make themselves visible to each other (such as by sharing content and liking or commenting on posts), and how content is displayed. Users can be individuals like me and you, but also political campaigns, political parties, major brands, and local businesses. Programming also determines how users interact with information. Think of a Google search – the results that are returned are the complex outcome of how the company weights webpages based on the authority of their connections to other sites Google sees as credible (what it calls “PageRank”). These are programming choices, and as such are *social* choices – not neutral features of the technology (Noble 2018; Svensson 2021).

The functioning of platform algorithms and interfaces is a primary way that platforms keep users engaged and coming back to spend time on them, thus generating more interactions with advertising and therefore even more revenue for the companies that maintain them. Indeed, this is central to their business models. Many of the American and other global platforms are offered as (mostly) free services, paid for primarily through digital advertising that commoditizes the data, time, attention, content, and relations of users. While users certainly derive value from these mostly free services, the economic returns of the time and attention spent on platforms and data generated by them flow back to their owners, shareholders, and employees (in the form of salaries, or sometimes stock options). In order to derive (ostensibly) free value from platforms (while also helping to collectively produce their profits through user-generated content), users have to adhere to platforms’ terms of service (or “user agreements”), which govern what they can do, including what they can say on them.

As our model shows, platforms are now at the center of media systems, and therefore political systems. This does not mean that platforms are the *only* forms of media in contemporary media and political systems. It means that platforms are the most important forms of media in politics because they are central to what every actor does. Journalists are centrally reliant on platforms to communicate with audiences, as are politicians for their communication with constituents. Citizens get the bulk of their political information from platforms (including the products of professional news media). Consider the role of Apple and Spotify in political podcasting as well. And, in a world where streaming through sites such as Netflix and Hulu has eclipsed broadcast and cable in the United States, platforms are now central to other forms of media (such as entertainment).

This means that commercial platform companies (in much of the West) and state-backed companies (such as those owned or directed by Russia and China) play an increasingly central role in shaping, structuring, and even governing public spheres and political processes in countries around the world. Through their design, functioning, and content policies, platforms shape public attention, the distribution of political information, and the forms, types, and content of political expression that people engage in. In countries around

the world, platforms shape the distribution of news, the audiences for media outlets, the format and types of stories, newsgathering, the user-generated political expression that is allowed (often in accord with international human rights frameworks), flows of political information, and possibilities to affiliate with others in groups. It's for these reasons that authorities in conflict-hit Ethiopia in August 2021 announced state-sanctioned measures to build the Horn of Africa nation's own social media platform to rival the dominant Facebook, Twitter, and WhatsApp (Oluwole 2021).

SPOTLIGHTED CONTENT

To take one example of how platforms shape politics, they make distribution less of a capital-intensive effort for publishers. This means that newer, often resourceleaner, outlets that publish digital-only have newfound ability to grow, monetize content, and gain sizable reach and attention – a big part of the problem around monetized “fake news” websites! At the same time, individual citizens with smartphones, social movements pursuing their causes, and authoritarians with an intent to subvert their accountability also have new opportunities in the era of platforms. Indeed, it is the contests between many different actors like these in platformmediated environments that define a lot of political communication today.

3.3 What Platforms Mean for Political Communication

Like everything else, what platforms mean for political communication, public opinion, the stability of governments, distribution of power in societies, and political processes is complicated. Platforms have given rise to an unprecedented richness and diversity in political information, and have enabled citizens to access a stunning array of sources. They have also facilitated the ability of commercial entities to monetize entirely “fake news” content and have made the sharing of mis- and disinformation – especially by political elites – to wide audiences much easier and faster than during the era of mass media. Given that they optimize for engagement, the most extreme or emotional content on platforms often finds greater reach and spread online than in offline contexts, where social norms can make people hesitant to say controversial things.

Is all this bad? Maybe. While some have pointed to the polarization that platforms create (Bail 2022), others demonstrate that communication on platforms promotes political participation (Boulianne 2020) and has been central to *global* movements for democracy and racial and social justice (Jackson et al. 2020). Platforms create the conditions for new forms of documentation and witnessing that help hold powerful actors, such as the police, accountable (Richardson 2020). In other words, platforms are celebrated for promoting political engagement and allowing a greater diversity of voices into global public spheres, even as they raise fears of disinformation, polarization, populism, and extremism.

Table 1 The most important platforms for political communication

Source: Table based on Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism's *Digital News Report 2021* (<https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/digital-news-report/2021/interactive>). Created by the authors.

Country	People who use social media for news (2021)(%)	Most popular platform for news (2021)
EUROPE		
United Kingdom	41	Facebook
Germany	31	Facebook
France	38	Facebook
Italy	47	Facebook
Spain	55	Facebook
Portugal	55	Facebook
Ireland	51	Facebook
Norway	44	Facebook
Sweden	47	Facebook
Finnland	45	Facebook
Denmark	46	Facebook
Belgium	38	Facebook
Netherlands	37	Facebook
Switzerland	47	WhatsApp
Austria	48	Facebook
Hungary	63	Facebook
Slovakia	56	Facebook
Czech Republic	50	Facebook
Poland	59	Facebook
Romania	58	Facebook
Bulgaria	67	Facebook
Croatia	54	Facebook
Greece	69	Facebook
ASIA		
Turkey	61	YouTube
Japan	24	YouTube
South Korea	42	YouTube
Taiwan	54	Line

Country	People who use social media for news (2021)(%)	Most popular platform for news (2021)
Hong Kong	61	Facebook
Malaysia	72	Facebook
Singapore	57	Facebook and Whatapp
Philippines	72	Facebook
India	63	YouTube and WhatsApp
Indonesia	64	WhatsApp
Thailand	78	Facebook
AMERICAS		
United States	42	Facebook
Canada	55	Facebook
Brazil	63	Facebook
Argentina	66	Facebook
Chile	69	Facebook
Mexico	67	Facebook
Colombia	70	Facebook
Peru	70	Facebook
AFRICA		
South Africa	75	Facebook
Kenya	76	WhatsApp
Nigeria	78	WhatsApp
Australia	47	Facebook

All of these things raise significant questions, and concerns, about how political communication works in our era. In a world of platforms, who has the power to shape public attention and matters of public concern – and to what ends? Who has the power to shape policymaking agendas? Who has the power to determine what can, and cannot, be said? How do platforms affect the balance of power between various actors, from movements to elected officials? And, who should have power in the public sphere?

3.4 Platforms Are Not Neutral Technologies

Imagine a football or soccer pitch. The rectangular green bordered by crisp white sidelines that clearly demarcate boundaries. The midfield line and center circle. The marked-off penalty and goal areas. At first thought, it is hard to imagine a more neutral technology – it's just a pitch, it treats everyone equally, allowing nothing but skill, endurance, strategy, and team organization to shine.

After further consideration, however, it becomes clear that even this simple technology is not neutral. Whether the turf is artificial or real grass favors certain athletes who perform

better on one than the other. Not every soccer pitch is the same size, so players will find relative advantages and disadvantages differentially across games. The dimensions might reward some types of skills and forms of training, for instance – such as endurance running – and not others – such as sprinting. Left-footed and right-footed players clearly have different strengths on different sides of the field, and different angles to be played to their strengths. If a football pitch is not neutral, think of a global platform such as Facebook. It too has an ostensibly neutral set of features, available to everyone. In most countries, anyone 13 and up can create a Facebook profile after answering questions about a predetermined set of categories. Anyone can post a range of images, videos, and text; comment and follow friends, neighbors, and causes; and share what others have posted. And anyone can see and respond to advertisements, the monetary lifeblood of the platform.

Again though, on further consideration, we would be hard pressed to imagine a more complicated, and less neutral, technology. The Facebook algorithms – which help determine what content gets reach and attention – reward emotion and are designed for engagement, not *necessarily* reason and deliberation (Bucher 2021). The content that gets the most attention – whether it is something your uncle, the *New York Times*, the United Nations, or a president shared – is conditioned by a mix of timing (favoring recency), follower (or ‘friend’) structure, the features of the message (such as emotional content, and cat videos!), the context it is released in (what else is vying for attention, what do people want to pay attention to at a particular point in time?), and engagement (content that performs well – such as getting likes and shares – gets even more visibility). Even more, this complex mix of ingredients changes depending on what the platform continually determines encourages people to spend more time on it, and new people to sign up.

All of this has vast consequences for political communication. We will provide three examples. First, in its enormous reach and power over attention, Facebook structures the marketplace for digital journalism, making or breaking many publishers reliant on web traffic (Bailo et al. 2021a; Meese & Hurcombe 2021) and digital ads. Second, Facebook’s policies on political ads, including its definition of allowable targeting and its real-time auctions of audiences, shapes how candidates run for office (Barrett 2021). Finally, Facebook groups provide millions of people around the world with an easy way to organize at scale, including around harmful conspiracy theories that undermine democratic deliberation (Krafft & Donovan 2020; Malinen 2021).

Technological infrastructures underpin much of contemporary political communication – and they are globally coordinated and dependent upon thousands of decisions that are in themselves political, such as the creation of standards (DeNardis 2014). Like media, technologies are not inherently good or bad. Nuclear technology can be used both to generate electricity and to build weapons of mass destruction. But technology is not neutral either. Thinkers have long argued that technologies carry with them the intentions of those societies, groups, people, organizations, and institutions who created them and whom they serve – their norms and values, worldviews, interests, and business models. And technologies are often the *outcomes* of conflicts between many stakeholders. For example, with regard to algorithms, the technology that mediates much of political and social life in countries around the world, Tarleton Gillespie (2014: 167) argues that we “must not conceive of algorithms as abstract, technical achievements, but must unpack the warm human and institutional choices that lie behind these cold mechanisms.” This makes algorithmic ethics necessary (Ananny 2016).

In other words, platforms are not purely mathematical and electrical entities. As detailed above, platforms are designed and curated communication systems, and they come in many varieties. Platforms have been deliberately designed to function and perform in specific ways. In many cases, as we noted above, they are commercial, for-profit entities and have data at the core of their business models (which they use to monetize their users). Communication on digital platforms does not take place in a vacuum or in a neutral space, but in a space which neither political actors nor citizens have complete ownership or control over – although they can and do assert a lot of pressure, whether it is regulatory or in the court of public opinion, both of which can have significant impact on the policies and functioning of platforms (Barrett & Kreiss 2019).

The particular *ways* in which platforms make certain things easier to do, incentivize certain forms of speech and action, and structure reach and attention means they have taken on central roles in shaping political communication around the world. And they do so in ways we are only beginning to grapple with today. Facebook (and Instagram and WhatsApp), Google and YouTube, TikTok/Douyin, Twitter, Snapchat, VKontakte, Alibaba, Wechat, and Weibo are increasingly, unmistakably, and powerfully setting the rules and providing the structures for much of public (and private!) communication in political and social life.

SPOTLIGHTED CASES

To take an example, in the US and Europe, YouTube has received a lot of attention for its potential role in politics, especially in the context of radicalization (Munger & Phillips 2022). YouTube uses data about users – such as their preferences for particular kinds of content and their responsiveness to particular types of advertising – to recommend content to those users. Recommendations are fundamentally the platform's guesses about what users will be most likely to enjoy or respond to, given the company's desire to keep them engaged and therefore spending more time on the platform. YouTube, like nearly all platforms, wants to keep its users engaged for commercial reasons. More engagement means more market share for the streaming platform and, ultimately, more revenue from digital advertising.

As many have pointed out, the complicated thing about platforms is that what is often good for *business* might not be good for *democracy*, or *society* more broadly. If the content that is most likely to keep users engaged is the most extreme, outrageous, polarizing, or emotionally charged, or otherwise leads people down a path of becoming more extreme in their political views, it might lead people to lose their tolerance of those with opposing views, see the political opposition as illegitimate, or embrace extremism and violence. The research jury is still out on these things, however. There is ample debate and mixed evidence, for instance, about whether social media leads people to more extreme views, or whether it reinforces existing preferences. Or, most likely, some combination of both, with political beliefs leading to media choices that further reinforce political beliefs (Young & Bleakley 2020). But it is also worth noting that many extreme views across history are ones majorities in many countries see as morally good today – such as an embrace of equality for LGBTQIA+ people, and civil rights for people of color.

Indeed, the very same algorithms and their incentivizing of content assisted the massive growth and political power of the international Black Lives Matter movement (Jackson et

al. 2020) *and* the Stop the Steal rally that led to the assault on the US Congress. All of which means that, when evaluating the relationship between platforms and democracy, we always have to consider the *ends* toward which they are used, and by whom. That said, a starting point of concern is more than justified because platforms such as YouTube are primarily commercial enterprises, without the same commitment to public welfare or, in democratic countries, rights and equality that institutions of the state or professions such as journalism often have.

Let's consider now the sources of platform power over the political and media systems of which they are now a central part.

3.5 The Dimensions of Platform Power

Let's break down some of the dimensions of platform power. Platforms hold considerable power, although it is not absolute (which we take up in the accountability section of this chapter). We focus here specifically on *politics* – again, expansively defined throughout this book in terms of matters of potential public concern.

In their important book *The Power of Platforms: Shaping Media and Society*, the media and communication scholars Rasmus Kleis Nielsen and Sarah Anne Ganter (2022) present an extensive discussion of platform power vis-à-vis publishers. We highlight and build upon a few of their central claims here.

Market Power

Perhaps one of the most obvious facts about the global economy is the increasing domination of advertising and information markets by large technology firms based primarily in the United States and China. The increasing concentration of market power means that companies such as Meta and Google have become central players in digital political advertising in the US and many countries around the world, attracting significant political ad revenues and being able to control data relevant to politics (Barrett 2021). Outside of companies such as Meta and Google, which count digital advertising among their primary sources of revenue, other platforms dominate other sectors. This includes cloud computing (Amazon and Microsoft), smartphones (Apple and Google), logistics and distribution (Amazon), and, increasingly, digital hardware and services (Meta).

The market power of platforms has downstream effects on politics. As digital advertising revenue migrates toward platforms, it moves away from journalism and other political media outlets. Meanwhile, platform control over digital advertising means they increasingly set the rules for political speech – and currently there are few forms of public accountability over their content and targeting rules.

For example, in the United States the decline in revenue for journalism (and especially newspapers) is an old phenomenon. Newspapers have been losing revenue to television and other media for decades. Regardless, this was amplified as non-profit platforms such as Craigslist captured classified advertising, and companies such as Meta and Google came to dominate markets for digital advertising. These market dynamics affect the revenue available to support things such as local journalism (Hindman 2018), and shape the business strategies of the news media itself (Usher 2021). At the same time, platforms are also economic drivers of other industries in new ways, such as opening up local advertising markets – which in turn has lowered the cost of efficiently reaching local voters.

As platforms become the locus for political advertising, they in turn set the policies for paid political speech that candidates and causes must adhere to for access to their audiences (Barrett 2021; Kreiss & McGregor 2018, 2019). Meanwhile, state-backed or state-interested platform companies often have to abide by state rules over expression – increasingly a concern to American scholars as Chinese platforms including Weibo, WeChat, and TikTok have gained a dominant presence, rivaling (or exceeding) American giants such as Meta and Twitter.

Meanwhile, the dominance of a few platform companies in key software and hardware markets has enabled these companies to control access to audiences at various layers in the technology “stack” (Gillespie et al. 2020). The “stack” refers to the layers of technology – from hardware, operating systems, and services to web applications – which varying platforms exercise control over at different levels. Again, this market power has significant political implications. Amazon banned the right-wing Twitter alternative Parler from its server infrastructure for a time after January 6, 2022, and Google initially denied the Donald Trump-backed alternative social media platform Truth Social access to its Android stores (the latter over a lack of content moderation policies). Regardless of the merits of any of these decisions, this means that a few commercial firms control access to significant portions of political audiences through their power over layers of the technology stack.

Distributional and Attention Power

Extending from this, companies such as Meta and Google in the United States, and Chinese-owned companies such as TikTok and WeChat, have increasing control over the distribution of information and public attention. Consider the ways in which many platforms are essentially privately maintained, public forums for much political news, media, debate, discussion, and contestation. It is impossible to imagine a political campaign today in many countries without accounting for the role of WhatsApp as a central vehicle for people to discuss politics; without Facebook being a key platform for campaigns to run targeted digital advertising to register voters and find supporters to volunteer and give money (Rossini et al. 2021); and without Twitter (especially in the United States) being the central vehicle for elected officials to issue press releases, respond to events (or incite them), and otherwise communicate with the press. Relatedly, political activists in countries around the world also use platforms such as Twitter in the attempt to influence the *American* press, especially when they want to get their messages in front of US elites.

Broadly, distributional power includes the ways in which platforms play increasingly important roles in controlling the flow of political communication in countries around the world. They do so in hybrid media environments where international and national television outlets, radio, and news websites continue to also play large roles shaping the distribution of political information and public and elite attention, to be sure. However, platforms are increasingly *the* central sites for the distribution of the content of these other media actors as well – in the process, giving them an outsized role in shaping public attention. And, as noted above, they do so through the policies, technical designs, and algorithms that reward certain types of content and select for certain types of engagement and not others – which in turn shapes the communicative incentives that many different political entities (including journalists) abide by.

Intermediary Power

Relatedly, platforms are intermediaries in a number of industries that they in turn indelibly shape. From public health to politics, commercial services to sports, entertainment to law and policymaking, platforms are now increasingly among the most important intermediaries that organize communication between various actors according to their own logics (Van Dijck et al. 2018). Indeed, platforms are a special kind of intermediary that not only serve as a go-between between content providers and audiences – they organize that content in deeply influential ways, including ordering it, incentivizing it, differentially making it accessible, determining what is acceptable and what is not, and ranking it (Gillespie 2017). In the process, these intermediaries structure interactions in particular ways.

Let's think about just a few of the ways platforms exercise intermediary power. By their very design, and depending on the platform, they structure *organizational* and *self-presentation* (by determining the categories for disclosure), *connections* (by the various ways they encourage ties to others or institutional bodies), *sociality* (by their differential capacity to support groups, anonymous versus public communication, the types of ties that are encouraged, etc.), *commercial transactions* (such as determining the possibilities for digital advertising and marketing, marketplace transactions, organizing interactions between buyers and sellers, etc.), and forms of *expression* itself (how many words or characters are permitted in posts, whether and how images render, the length of time available for videos or possibilities to livestream, etc.). In doing so, platforms serve as intermediaries that structure relationships across a host of different domains of political, social, economic, and religious life.

Content Power

Nearly all the major platforms have express content policies (and, as detailed above, when they control access to servers and stores, they also can force policies on other entities, including other platforms). These policies have outsized importance in politics, and have increasingly become a flashpoint around the world in debates over “free speech,” especially notably with the rise of populist and authoritarian governments and politicians, anti-democratic movements, and mis- and disinformation.

It is worth remembering that content moderation policies are necessary for these commercial enterprises. Content policies are what enable platforms to run services that are free of pornography, for instance, or illegal activities such as the buying and selling of illicit drugs. Where platforms draw the line between what is permitted and what is not is often contested, however. While there is a large domain of content that is unquestionably and legitimately moderated by platforms (such as pornography and terrorist content), there are many, many debates around other significant categories of speech that these companies have sought to moderate in the face of internal, external, or commercial pressures. The more that political and social norms are unsettled and contested in societies, the more platform policies are the subject of political controversy – indeed, debates over platform content moderation efforts are often proxies for larger political struggles.

SPOTLIGHTED CASES

To provide a few examples of political controversies over content moderation, in the wake of the 2016 US presidential election there was increasing pressure on Facebook and Instagram, Google and YouTube, and Twitter to reduce hate speech, disinformation, and content that might dissuade people from voting – even though these things are very much allowed under the US’s First Amendment (and there is often very little the US government can do to regulate this content). Many of these calls came in the wake of the high-profile revelations related to the Cambridge Analytica scandal – a company that obtained Facebook data on millions of Americans and Britons and engaged in targeted digital political advertising to sway them during the US presidential election and “Brexit,” in contravention of the platform’s policies – as well as Russian state-sponsored disinformation attempts during the cycle.

In response to public pressure in the US and European Union, over the past decade a number of platforms have developed an increasingly expansive (and often confusing) set of rules around permissible content, which are continual sites of challenge. These rules have proven difficult to enforce and justify. What exactly constitutes a false claim in politics, related to the processes and procedures of voting? Where is the line between raising legitimate questions about the fairness of a vote versus a strategic attempt to undermine electoral accountability? When is discussion about vaccinations for Covid-19 part of a good-faith debate as opposed to strategic attempts to undermine the public’s faith in health systems? These are not easy questions, and platforms have routinely struggled with answering them. Even more, platforms are as conflicted as our *societies* increasingly are about the authority of, and trust we should place in, all sorts of knowledge-producing institutions, including journalism. And our societies are also conflicted about who we should trust to make judgment calls about speech – and, indeed, whether we should make them at all.

Some governments have sought to pass laws that promote freedom of expression in the wake of various crises – which remains a powerful democratic ideal. In the US, there have been no fewer than a dozen state and federal proposed bills requiring platforms to serve as neutral channels for speech since 2016, much in the way that phone companies are. In Brazil, populist President Jair Bolsonaro in 2021 implemented a rule requiring that social media platforms maintain their neutrality and support political freedom of expression. In many countries, platforms are often at the center of political struggles between some parties (including those with anti-democratic ends) that seek to elevate the freedom of expression beyond every other democratic value, and those that see the ways expression can be weaponized to undermine public discourse, democratic accountability, and democratic institutions (Franks 2020). Platforms, meanwhile, have their own values which shape what they are willing to support, countenance, and amplify. But they also have a set of commitments to their shareholders for maximizing revenue, as well as a set of near- and long-term market concerns, which means they rarely want to be the breeding ground for deception and disinformation and extremist political movements – which likely turns off many users, much like pornography does.

Economic Power

Many platforms also control an immense amount of capital that critics argue allows them to distort the market for goods and services and have outsized influence over labor markets. In the US and Europe, in particular, there are spirited debates over whether platforms concentrate too much economic power, distort prices and competition, and subvert markets in many sectors of the economy. As a result, there are ongoing struggles to regulate these platform companies amid debates over what the nature of the problem is, and what to do, in countries where platforms have taken on a significant role in economic and social life (Boczkowski & Mitchelstein 2021).

While we spend less time discussing the impact of platforms in domains outside of politics in this book, it is important to note the political aspects of things such as anti-trust law in the United States – where many prominent platforms are based. Various proposals, for instance, have argued that platforms distort various markets to such an extent that they need to be either broken up or prevented from making further acquisitions. Platforms, in turn, have argued that it is their very scale that enables them to effectively take action against things such as hate speech and disinformation, and the fragmentation of global public spheres and the comparatively fewer resources of smaller platforms would mean a proliferation of extremism across niche platforms. Potential regulatory efforts, in turn, have pointed to the ways in which many platforms have pursued growth at all costs, including when they lack resources and knowledge (such as language competency) to protect their users in new, or non-English-speaking, markets. At the same time, established platforms point to the emergence of new ones – such as the rapid global rise of TikTok – as evidence for the competitiveness of the markets they are in.

Technological Power

We have referred to “algorithms” before, but let’s consider them in greater depth here. The term “algorithm” is used expansively in public discourse, including to deflect responsibility for human decisions, especially by platform companies looking to explain away some harmful aspect of their technology – such as statements that “the algorithm did it” (Lum & Chowdhury 2021). Etymologically, the word “algorithm” comes from the Greek word for number, “arithmos,” and the Arabic word for calculation, “al-jabr” (from which “algebra” stems – see Striplas [2015]). Most definitions center on algorithms being a set of rules – a multiple-step process to produce specific outputs (Kitchin 2017) and a way of automated decision-making. Just like in a baking recipe, the automated decision-making behind the user interfaces of platforms consists of data (ingredients) and concise steps of execution (recipe instructions) processing the data.

SPOTLIGHTED CONTENT

Data are not neutral. After all, there are many things in the world that could be counted! How things are counted and why, what actions produce data and what do not, are all social – and often economic – decisions. Ultimately, data do not represent things that are actually in the world; they are “constructs” of things in the world. Moreover, data are uncertain, messy, imperfect, and social – so much so that, as Hong (2020) argues, datafication creates “data-driven fabrication” and, ultimately, “technologies of speculation,” rather than objective truth.

Although they are often represented as purely technological, algorithms are human-made, and they run based on data that is both messy and constructed for particular organizational ends. In the context of platforms, algorithms are often commercial products. They are instrumental in that they are programmed to achieve certain goals, such as generating revenue according to business models; and they reflect the worldviews and experiences of their creators and the economic, political, and regulatory contexts they operate in. Algorithms can also have unintended consequences. As a growing number of researchers have documented, algorithms quite often produce discrimination and racist, sexist, and classist results – and, even worse, they scale, reinforcing and amplifying discrimination through biased automated decision-making (Eubanks 2018; Noble 2018; Sandvig et al. 2016).

How do the algorithms that platforms design and implement, and that in turn drive platforms, have power? In classical political theory, “power” refers to the opportunity to impose one’s will on others, even against their resistance (Weber 1921/1968). Communication power, as Manuel Castells (2007) defines it, means that “the media are not the holders of power, but they constitute by and large the space where power is decided” (2007: 242). However, we see more expansive ways in which platforms wield power. Moisés Naím (2014), for instance, has elaborated on the classical definition: “Power is the ability to direct or prevent the current or future actions of other groups and individuals. Or, put differently, power is what we exercise over others that leads them to behave in ways they would not otherwise have behaved” (2014: 16). Naím distinguishes four power resources: persuasion, coercion, obligation, and rewards.

This is helpful for understanding algorithms and power. Here we can distinguish the power *of* algorithms, power *through* algorithms, and power *over* algorithms (Klinger 2023). With respect to the first, algorithmic systems can *persuade* (e.g. lure people into staying longer on platforms than they want to); they can *coerce* users (e.g. by giving users only defined options to communicate or behave, and foreclosing other options); they can *obligate* users to obey their rules out of “sunk-costs,” or the time a user has already dedicated to a platform (e.g. users cannot migrate their network of followers from one platform to another, so that being de-platformed or leaving a platform is difficult); and they can *reward* users for compliant behavior (e.g. with more reach in return for personal data).

Programmers and designers, platform companies and advertising firms, even parties who create their own apps and harvest voter data, have power *through* algorithms. As detailed above, algorithms are social technologies and, as such, social biases get programmed into these technologies. The profession of programmers has long been riddled by a lack of

gender, racial, ethnic, and class diversity. Although programming was originally a typical women's profession, today it is mostly white and Asian men who work in the tech industry in the US and Europe and design platforms, apps, dating portals, and messenger services. In Google's tech workforce at the time of this writing, for example, 36.9 percent of employees are white males, and 33.5 percent are Asian male workers. In contrast, only 0.9 percent of Google's tech employees are Black women, and 1.3 percent are Latinx/Hispanic women (Google 2021: 59).

There is also power *over* algorithms that only very few people can exercise. For instance, the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Meta, Mark Zuckerberg, can decide how much local journalism users find in their Facebook news feed, and can change this whenever he wishes – with massive effects on local news organizations. While Facebook is a complex company with a lot of considerations – such as commercial concerns – at the end of the day those who own or govern platforms have power over things such as algorithmic content moderation at massive scales, including the definitions of prohibited content. They also decide the performance goals of their algorithmic systems, how to weigh different types of popularity cues (such as likes, shares, comments), and whether and how the malevolent side-effects of their algorithms should be remedied, or not. And, taking this to an extreme, Elon Musk demonstrates (while we are writing this book) how one owner can disrupt, and capriciously make decisions that affect, millions of users on an entire platform.

Another prominent example is Facebook's changes in the run up to the 2020 election. That autumn, Facebook banned content from the international conspiracy movement QAnon. The platform also made the decision to tweak its news algorithms in the crucial period shortly before and after the 2020 US elections – to make the platform “nicer,” to prioritize news from what the company considers authoritative sources as opposed to hyper-partisan sources, and to combat disinformation about the election. Soon after the election, however, and well before January 6, the platform generally rolled back a number of these policies (Joe Osborne, a Facebook spokesman, said this was “a temporary change we made to help limit the spread of inaccurate claims about the election” [Roose et al. 2020]). As the *New York Times* noted, “Other measures Facebook has developed to combat political misinformation and hate speech have been scaled back or vetoed by executives in the past, either because they hurt Facebook's usage numbers or because executives feared they would disproportionately harm right-wing publishers, several Facebook employees told The Times last month” (Roose 2020).

The rollback of these changes in turn likely created more opportunities for groups such as “Stop the Steal” to organize on the platform – of course, culminating in the attempted coup on January 6, 2021. Meanwhile, Twitter allowed Trump and other actors to spread lies about the vote in the aftermath of the election, stepped up enforcement after the violence at the US Capitol, and then stopped enforcing its “civic integrity” policies again in March 2021, according to public reporting (Dale 2022). Again, regardless of the merits of any of these policies, or their rollback, all of these examples illustrate the vast power platforms have over politics.

3.6 Summary

These events surrounding the 2020 US presidential election reveal the ways in which platforms such as Facebook are central to global politics. They are important forums for political debate and discussion, campaign attempts to mobilize and persuade their voters,

and elected officials' communications with the electorate. At the same time, they are seedbeds for the attempts of elected leaders to undermine their accountability at the ballot box through false claims of electoral malfeasance, and of actors to spread public health misinformation. They provide key opportunities for elected officials to connect with voters, while also creating the means for those same leaders and their supporters to undermine democracy.

Through it all, their immense power is on display. In deplatforming the defeated former president, Facebook, Twitter, and Google took actions after January 6 that other media outlets were not willing to take – Trump coverage was not banned on CNN, for instance. Leaders across the globe – including former German Chancellor Angela Merkel – spoke out against the Trump ban, concerned about what concentrating vast power in a handful of companies meant for their own countries and legitimate political rule. Others sought to ensure platforms worked to their advantage. In September 2021, for example, then Brazilian President Bolsonaro signed a directive blocking social media companies from removing content and accounts. Turkey had earlier on introduced new legislation requiring platforms with over 1 million users to employ a local representative who would remove content if deemed necessary. A few months after officially banning Twitter, Nigeria's internet regulator also came up with proposals to regulate platform-based content in 2022.

While there may be more platforms, and different ones, in the future, their power is not likely to attenuate any time soon, given the central role they play in politics around the world. In the chapters that follow, we show that platforms are now central to how all the main actors in public discourse and democratic governance act to influence publics and public spheres, pursue policy and other ends, and secure and wield power. And, as we return to in [Chapter 9](#), there are multiple mechanisms for platform governance – both self-governance through their policies and even independent oversight boards, and externally through public regulation.

Discussion Questions

- In most countries worldwide, Facebook is still the most important platform for political communication. However, newer and more popular platforms such as TikTok have emerged in the past years. Why is it that Facebook still remains a key player in political communication?
- Most commercial platforms are optimized for profit (e.g. through advertisements), not for facilitating meaningful public debate. If you were asked to design a platform that is beneficial for democracy and political discourse, what would it look like? What would be its key affordances?

Suggestions for Further Reading

Bucher, T. (2018) *If ... Then: Algorithmic Power and Politics*. New York: Oxford University Press.

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